

Gambia



Gambia is a riverbank state on the west coast of Africa, almost entirely surrounded by Senegal. It was renowned for its stability until its government was overthrown in a coup in 1994.



GEOGRAPHY

Located on the narrow strip of land bordering the Gambia River. Long, sandy beaches are backed by mangrove swamps along the river. Savanna and tropical forests higher up.



CLIMATE

Subtropical, with wet, humid months July–October, and warm, dry season November–May.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Little tension between various ethnic groups. The largest group, the Mandinka, has traditionally held power. Islam is a strong social influence, though there is no official state religion. A small expatriate community from the UK lives on the coast. Seasonal migrants come from neighboring states to harvest groundnuts each year. Women are very active as traders.

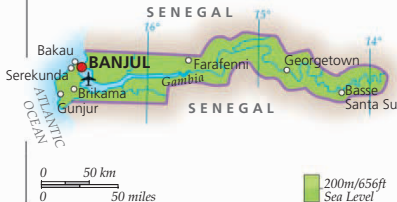


THE ECONOMY

Around 70% of the labor force is involved in agriculture. Groundnuts are the principal crop. Fish stocks are declining. Eco-tourism is promoted, though most visitors come for the beaches. Banjul is one of west Africa's finest deepwater ports: significant re-export trade. Smuggling problems.



INSIGHT: *Overfishing in the waters off Gambia and Senegal, mainly by foreign vessels, is a growing problem*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of the Gambia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1965

CAPITAL: Banjul

POPULATION: 1.71 million

TOTAL AREA: 4363 sq. miles
(11,300 sq. km)

DENSITY: 442 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Mandinka, Fulani, Wolof, Jola, Soninke, English*

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 90%, Christian 9%, traditional beliefs 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Mandinka 40%, Fulani 19%, Wolof 15%, Jola 11%, Serahuli 9%, other 6%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Dalasi = 100 butut